

INDIAN WRITINGS IN ENGLISH

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Syllabus — D - Detailed, NO - Not Detailed

Imp lessons in red are studied in each unit.

1. Unit-I

Tori Dutta - Sita, The Lotus, Our Casuarina Tree All D

Rabindranath Tagore - Gitanjali - 1 to 15 Songs D

Sarojini Naidu - Indian Dancers, Love and Death, The old Woman NO

2. Unit-II

Jayant Mahapatra - Indian Summer, A missing person, The Logic NO

Kamla Das - The Freaks, A Hot noon in Malabar, The Looking Glass, The Sunshine Cat NO

Nissim Ezekiel - Enterprise, Poet, doves, Birdwatchers Night of the Scorpion D

3. Unit - III

J. L. Nehru - Discovery of India NO

N. C. Choudhary - Autobiography of an Unknown Indian NO

Abdul Kalam - Ignited Minds D

4. Unit - IV

Girish Karnad - Nagamandala D

Shashi Deshpande - The Dark Holds No Terrors NO

Mahesh Dattani - Final Solutions NO

5. Unit - V

Raja Rao - Kanthapura NO

R. K. Narayan - The English Teachers NO

Anita Desai - Cry, The Peacock NO

Unit - 1

Rabindranath Tagore - Gitanjali - 1 to 15 Songs D

Summary and Context -

Gita = Song + Anjali = Offering →

"Gitanjali" = Song offering

It is an offering of songs to God. It is a collection of 103 poems translated by Tagore from his various poetical works in Bengali. The poems are devotional songs in which the poet expresses his thoughts, emotions and soul to God.

About the writer -

Rabindranath Tagore (1861-1941)

Era and Age - Bengal Renaissance, Modern Indian Literature (1860-1947), late 19th & Early 20th Century

Titles - Gurudev, Kaviguru, National poet of India

Admirers - W. B. Yeats, International literary community

Critics - Found his mysticism difficult to interpret.

Awards - 1913 Noble prize in literature for 'Gitanjali'

Contribution -

- First Asian Noble laureate in literature
- Introduced Indian Spirituality to the west.
- Enriched Indian English poetry.

Gitanjali - 1 to 15 Songs

It is mainly a collection of devotional songs. The lyrics are organized architecturally. They are arranged in logically connected groups.

Main groups -

i) First group (1-7) - Vastness and immensity of God's love, and his gifts and the deep relationship of love existing between God and the poet.

ii) Second (8-13) - Proper way to realize God.

is dealt with in here. He can be realized through love of humanity.

iii) Third (14-36) - Poet's intense yearning for union with God is emphasized. The obstacles in the way of God's realization and pangs of separation are also described.

Poems - Explanation and Symbolism

1. Poem 1 - "Thou Hast made me endless"

The human body is temple of Soul, the human Soul is the temple of God. The poet compares himself to a flute through which God's breath flows.

He prays his ego never blocks God's divine music.

Symbols - Divine Flute/Music - (God's call),
Empty vessel - Human body/Soul,
Immortal touch - Divine grace that gives meaning to human life.

2. Poem 2 - "When thou Commandest me to sing"

Poet feels whenever God ask him to sing. His heart becomes filled with joy.

His songs are not really his own - they come from divine inspiration.

3. Poem 3 - "I know not how thou singest, my master!"

Poet is amazed by God's mysterious music. He cannot understand how such divine beauty is created.

4. Poem 4 - "Like to my life, I shall even try to keep my body pure..."

Poet wants to keep his body and mind pure because God lives within him.

5. Poem 5 - "I ask for a moment's indulgence to sit by thy side..."

Poet allows him to sit beside him to sit but he is distracted by worldly work.

6. Poem 6 - "Pluck this little and take it, delay not!"

Poet compares his life to a small flower. He asks God to accept his life and love before it fades.

7. Poem 7 - "My Song has put on her adornments"

The poet rejects artificial religious ceremonies and elaborate rituals. He wants his relationship with God to be simple, sincere and direct.

8. Poem 8 - "The child who is decked with prince's robes..."

Contrasts the freedom of a child with the restrictions created by wealth and status. Material possessions can therefore become a kind of bondage.

9. Poem 9 - "O Fool, try to carry thyself upon thy shoulders!"

Criticizes human pride and the desire to control everything independently.

10. Poem 10 - "Here is thy footstool and these rest thy feet..."

Poet presents himself as a humble beggar before God. Instead of asking for material wealth, he seeks God's grace and presence.

11. "Leave this chanting and singing and telling of beads"

God is not found by escaping from ordinary life. God is working with the farmer, labourer and ordinary people.

12. "The time that my journey takes is long..."

Human life is a long journey. He realizes that his worldly possessions and attachment imprison him.

13. "The Song that I came to sing remains un sung to this day."

Poet feels he has not yet fulfilled the purpose of his life. He waits for the right moment when he can completely surrender himself to God.

14. "My desires are many and my cry is pitiful.."

Poet admits he has many worldly desires. He asks God to remove his unnecessary desires and make his heart ready to receive divine love.

15. "I am here to sing thee songs"

Poet sees singing as his life purpose. He wants to remain close to God and offer his songs to prayer.

Devotional and Mystical element in Gitanjali-

Mysticism - A person can have a direct spiritual experience or connection with God or the divine.

Dr. Tyengar - "The Gitanjali songs are mainly poems of 'bhakti' in the great Indian tradition."

The Poet sings with firm faith the glory of God who manifests himself in different shapes in human life and nature.

Dr. Radhakrishnan opines, "Being a poet, Rabindranath uses the visible world as a mean of shadowing forth the invisible."

Themes -

1. Man, Nature and God - He was a firm believer in the essential

unity of man and the external universe.

"When the light of sense goes out, but with a flash that has revealed."

2. The invisible world - Tagore feels that it is his duty, to keep his inner self absolutely pure because only then he can become worthy of being united with the Supreme Soul.

3. Mysticism - Tagore accepts life and enjoys the manifold beauties of life and nature enthusiastically, he is a spiritual realist.

He seeks union with God through union with his fellow-men.

4. Romanticism - Tagore is a romantic and he looks with a child-like wonder even at the most commonplace and trivial objects of nature.

5. Humanism - Tagore shows deep concern for human problems, suffering and heroism.

23/08/26

Nissim Ezekiel - Entrepreneur, Poet, lover, bird watcher, Night of the Scorpion D

About the writer -

Nissim Ezekiel (1924-2004)

Era & Age - Contemporary Indian literature, Contemporary period (1947 - present)

Titles - Father of Modern Indian English poetry

Admiration - Modern Poets, Literary Scholars

Critics - Critics considered his style too urban

Awards - Sahitya Akademi Awards (1983) - Later - Day Psalms

Contribution -

- Modernized Indian English Poetry
- Used Irony and realism effectively
- Portrayed Indian life authentically
- Used clear, conversational language
- Made English poetry feel more authentically Indian.

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1. Enterprise -

Summary and Context -

Enterprise means an important undertaking or journey. It refers to a significant expedition or pilgrimage here.

A group of travelers starts a pilgrimage hoping for spiritual fulfillment but gradually loses purpose and unity.

Symbolism -

Journey - Human life, pilgrimage - Search for truth and meaning

Failure of journey - Human disappointment

Themes - Spiritual Conquest, Human weakness, Self-Discovery

Description - An allegorical poem describing the journey of life and the poet's realization at different stages of his journey.

The way was not smooth for the poet and his group. They face difficulties in

order to reach their goal. Some members leave the group for their differences of opinions.

The situation worsens when they are close to their destination. But the ending is paradoxical. Even after suffering from hardships to reach their goal, they feel dejected after reaching there.

At last, the poet paradoxically remarks -

"Home is where we have to gather grace."

2. Poet, Lover, Birdwatcher -

Summary and Context -

23/08/26 Poet tries to analyze the creative process of the poet and makes an attempt at defining it. He compares the poet in this sense, to a bird-watcher or lover.

It is only perseverance and inspiration that results in a natural form. Lovers and ornithologists do not rush their way towards things, they rather wait for the apt moment. A poet must proceed with great resolve for his poetic consciousness to comply with him.